

North Carolina looks more like a done deal for Democrats

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【メール原文】

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This is a tacit acknowledgement that the North Carolina race now leans strongly toward Democrats, and is their most likely flip this year. Democrats lead by around nine points in the polls there, far greater than their lead in virtually any other competitive state.

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Democrats will probably divert this funding to shoring up the somewhat soft races in their underbelly, particularly Michigan and New Hampshire; Republicans are planning on spending even more in their 'red wall' states—Texas, Ohio, Alaska—while also probing Democratic weakness in Minnesota.

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On balance, we doubt that spending movement in the final weeks of the campaign will be enough to shift the Senate race back toward Republicans; the national environment is too negative, and shows no signs of improvement. Still, this spending could be important in restraining the size of the Democratic majority, keeping it closer to 51 than to the 54 that is plausible in recent polling.

Clayton likely to be a national security voice as AI czar. President Trump named Jay Clayton, the Director of National Intelligence, as his new AI czar. Clayton is a former SEC chairman and former U.S. Attorney for the Southern District of New York.

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Clayton does not come from the tech industry and so represents a departure from previous AI Czar David Sacks, who was a notable tech cheerleader, champion of deregulation, and opponent of

open-weight model restrictions aimed at Chinese forms.

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Clayton is likely to be a stronger voice on national security than Sacks or other AI figures in the administration are; he has called AI a national-security issue in the past, currently serves as director of national intelligence, and as a full-time government employee—unlike Sacks—may have a more direct engagement with substantive policy questions in the White House.

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We do not expect that Clayton's elevation will change the internal balance of power, however; Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent will likely remain at the forefront of AI policy decision-making. Clayton's portfolio is still taking shape—he will lead a new body, the Super Intelligence Force, tasked with a new report on AI risks and opportunities and reporting directly to the Oval Office. Other members include FTC Chairman Andrew Ferguson and Under Secretary of Defense Emil Michael, and the board will coordinate between consumers, public-interest groups, religious organizations, critical infrastructure providers, and AI companies.

NATO posture review will bring troop reductions, not a Lithuania base. Lithuanian Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevicius offered to pay the cost for a US base in the country, if the US should choose to establish one. The base would be the first permanent US military installation in the Baltics.

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The US has maintained a rotational force presence of 1,000 troops in Lithuania since 2019. Lithuania, which borders Russia-aligned Belarus, has tried to attract a permanent US contingent in-country at its Camp Herkus facilities but did not gain traction with the Biden administration.

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Although the US has stated it will consider the offer, any basing agreement in Lithuania faces long odds, especially under President Trump. A permanent US facility would be a major friction point with Vladimir Putin, who would almost assuredly push back on such a proposal to Trump's personal envoys or Trump himself. Trump's administration has remained deferential to Kremlin concerns in search of business opportunities and off-ramps in the politically unpopular Ukraine war.

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While not likely in the short-term, Lithuania's basing offer will remain attractive moving forward. The Pentagon is likely to reduce its footprint in Europe as it faces a budget crunch and conducts its ongoing NATO posture review. In that process, a permanent base in Lithuania could be a cost-effective alternative to alter US posture in the region. Despite Trump's long-stated desire for partner countries to pay for bases abroad, we assess the Trump administration will decide against the base due to political cost of the move in Moscow; however, the proposal could gain traction under different political conditions or a new administration.

Quote of the Day

"Presumably if you prevail, the next day, a municipality in every single state will file a lawsuit that will probably copy your pleadings. How would you think that will work out on the ground?" - Supreme Court Chief Justice John Roberts yesterday during the Court's first day of oral arguments this term; the case argued centered on whether municipalities could sue private companies for the impacts of climate change, and a ruling in favor of the plaintiffs could, as Roberts pointed out, leave corporations vulnerable to an onslaught of similar suits.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

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